SELF ASSESSMENT

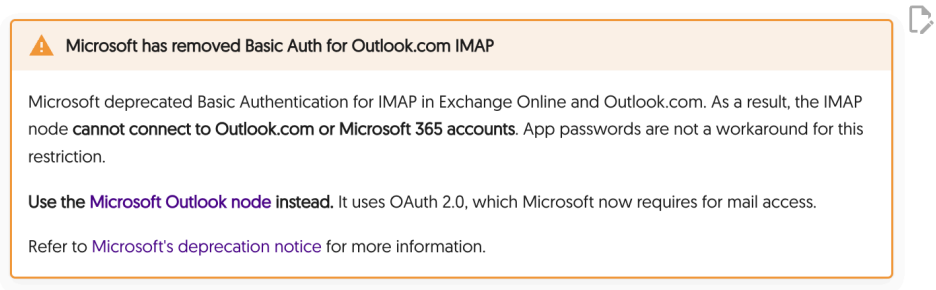
Overview of my experience

For someone working with n8n and automations for the first time, it was a little overwhelming at a few stages: I sat for hours debugging and trying to understand the problem, and had to change the whole workflow. But now that this project is complete, I can say I have a basic understanding of how automations work. There is still a lot to learn, and I will surely catch on. Overall, it was exciting to work on a new topic and implement it with no dependency on tutorials, an experience I will remember forever. It gave me the strength to explore and actually read through documentation without being totally dependent on AIs.

Problems faced during work

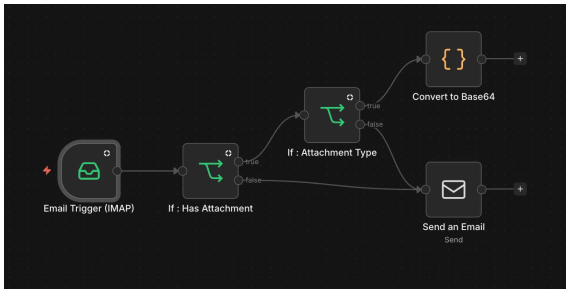
1. **Access denied to Microsoft developer program -**

   I didnt get the microsoft developer access so I switched to using imap on outlook, after setting it up when I tried to actually execute it the node wasnt fetching my emails and so I went through the documentation and found out that microsoft doesn't support IMAP approach anymore due to security reasons.And so I shifted from Outlook to Gmail IMAP.



2. **Gmail IMAP not fetching emails**

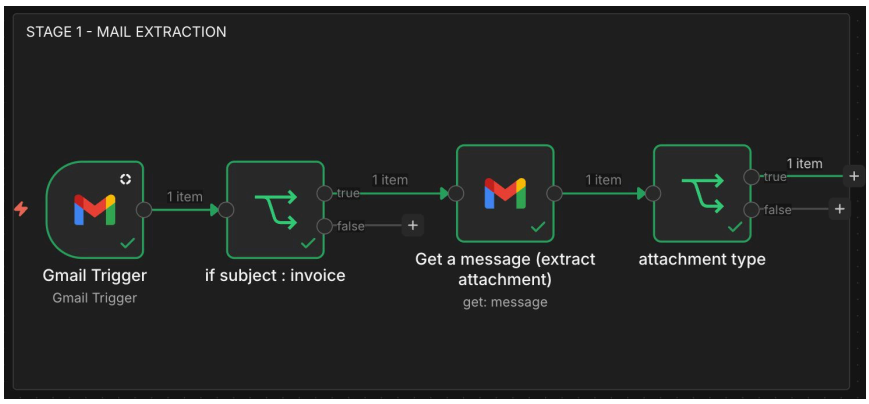
   I faced the same problem in gmails, but here the cause was different. It was due to my strict conditions on email. The “UNSEEN” and “Fetch only new emails - ON” was causing it not to be fetched. Once I changed the restrictions it worked.



3. **Base64 conversion on IMAP not working**

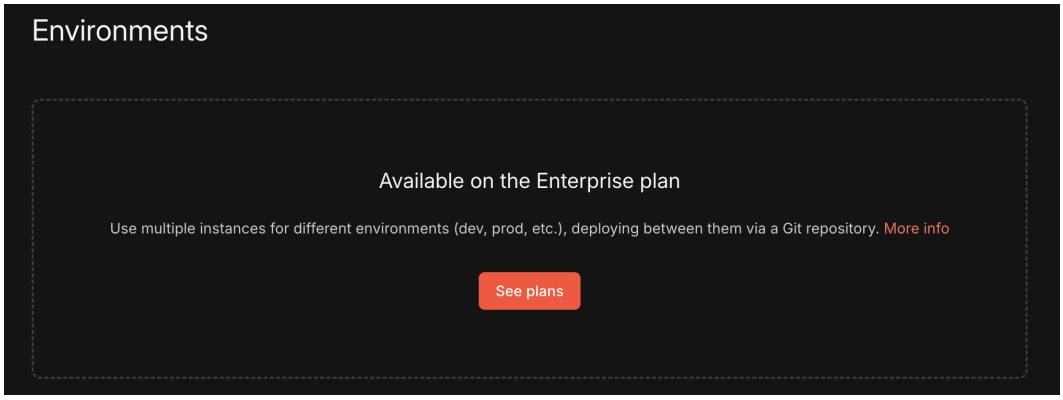
What I could understand from gpt is that it is classifying all my mail data into one metadata and defining the type as “mixed”, which included my attachments as well. Due to this firstly the attachment type couldn't be identified properly and the Base64 conversion wouldn't work either.

So then I shifted to Gmail Trigger, a much safer and directly downloaded attachment data to binary on GET a message node.



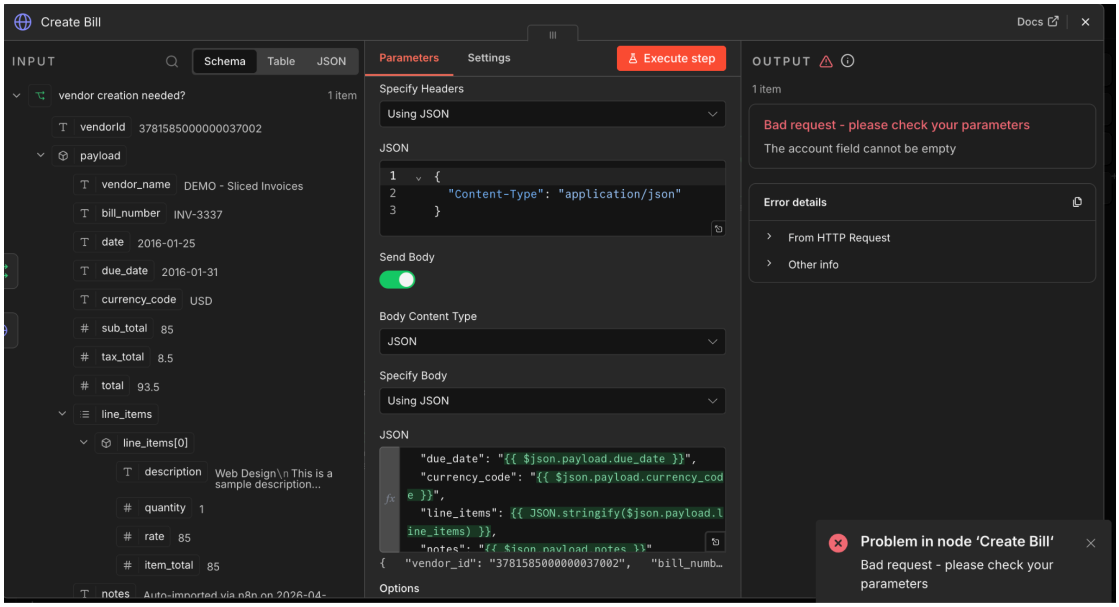
4. **Environment Set up**

When i tried setting up the gemini key into environments it showed that i need to upgrade, so searched for an alternative and tried to make an env in the docker container itself but it didn't work either. It gave an error saying “Cannot assign to read only property 'name' of object 'Error: access to env vars denied”. And so I have kept my api key and organization id hardcoded into the code. It is not an ethical way of keeping apis when it comes to production and I will surely try to find an alternative for the future use.



5. **Account id needed in Creating bill**

   Every bill has a specific account id classifying it into a category, my account id was empty so i downloaded the csv file “Chart of Accountants” and its types and tried to dynamically run it but it gave me a few errors, the classification was wrong, so i chose a safer option, I hardcoded the default account id “Other Expenses” into the json body.

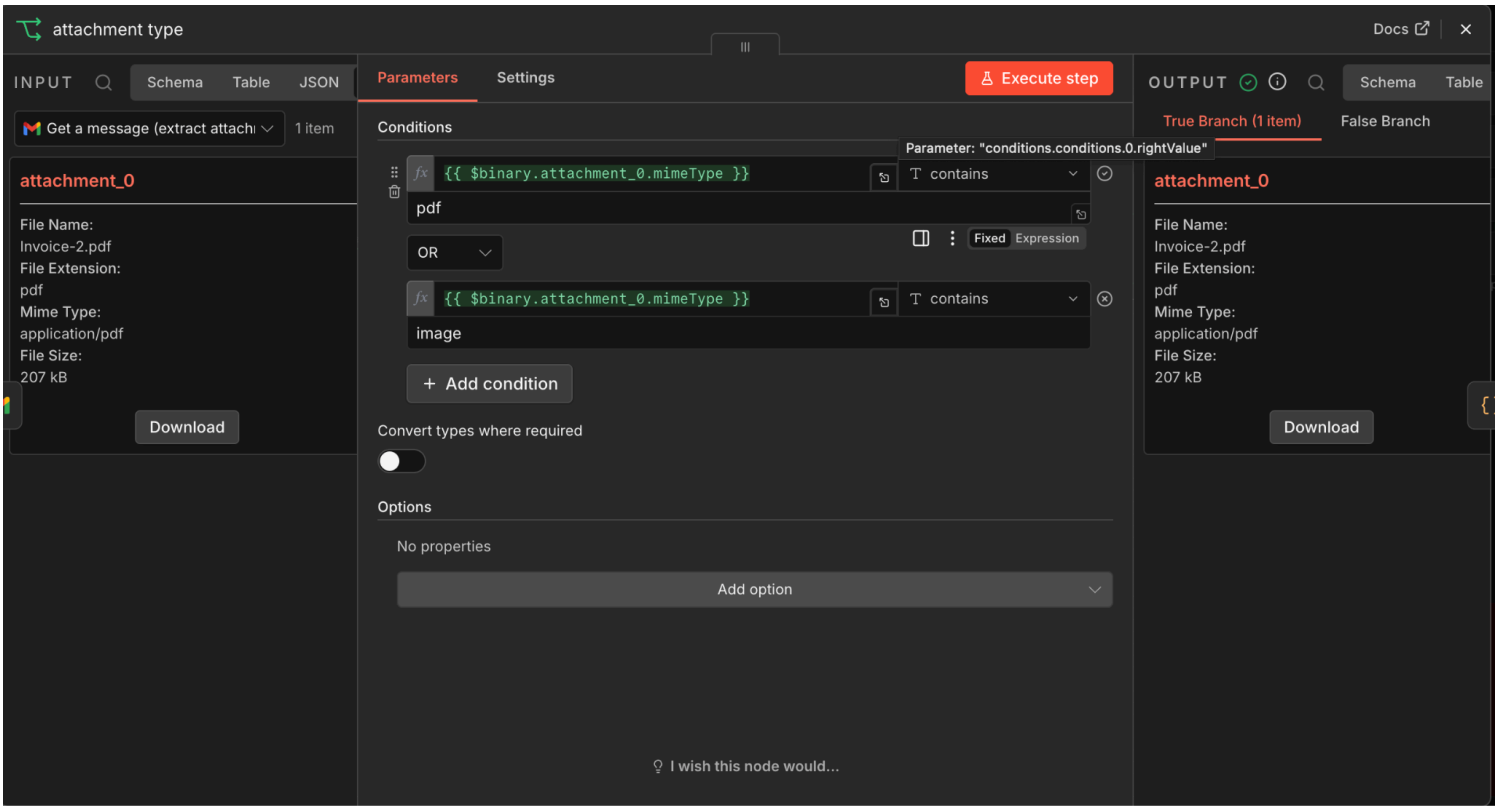


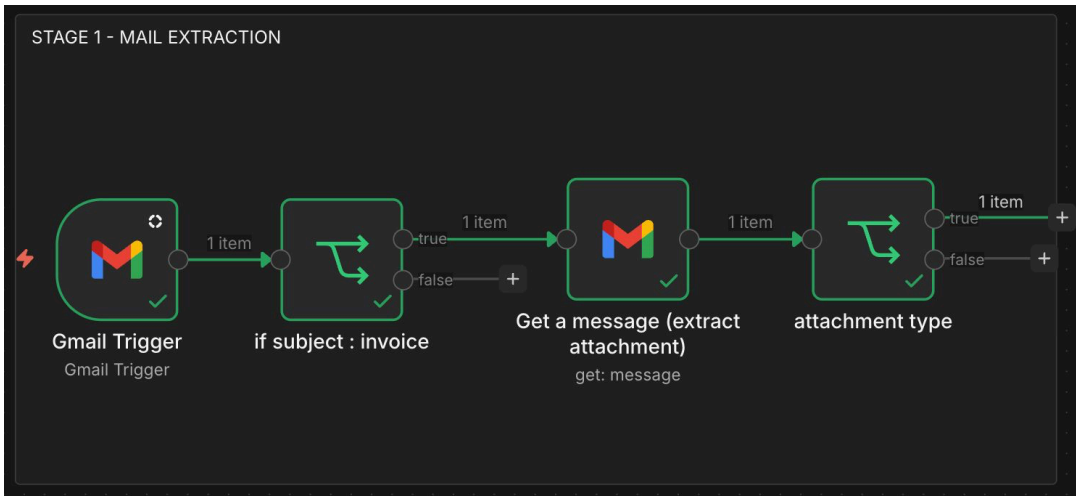
6. **Gemini Api key**

   The gemini-1.5 version was not working so i fetched the details of available models on my api key and used the gemini-2.5 model.

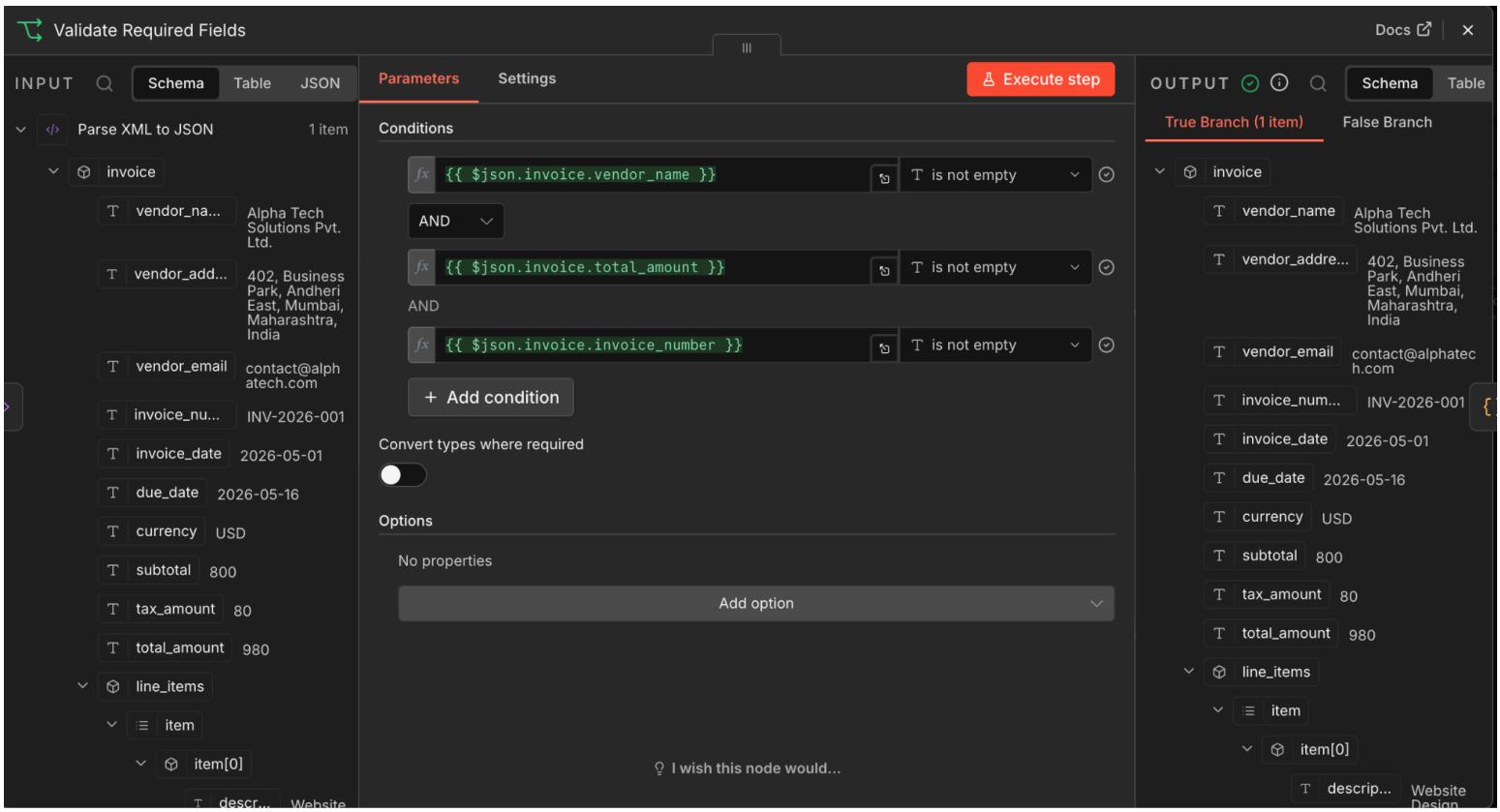
FINAL WORKING MODEL

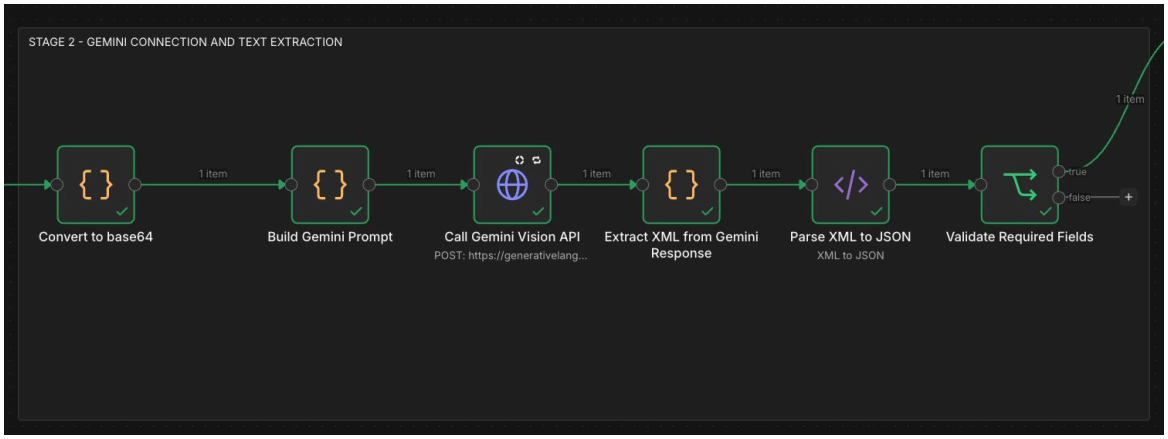
1. Stage 1 (fetching email and attachment type) - Complete





2. Stage 2 (Gemini configuration and text extraction) - Complete





3. Stage 3 (Zoho Books) - Complete

Create Bill

INPUT — Schema | Table | JSON

vendor creation needed?

True Branch | False Branch (1 item)


```
[
  {
    "vendorId": "3781585000000048001",
    "payload": {
      "vendor_name": "Alpha Tech Solutions Pvt. Ltd.",
      "bill_number": "INV-2026-001",
      "date": "2026-05-01",
      "due_date": "2026-05-16",
      "currency_code": "USD",
      "sub_total": 800,
      "tax_total": 80,
      "total": 980,
      "line_items": [
        {
          "description": "Website Design",
          "quantity": 1,
          "rate": 200,
          "item_total": 200
        },
        {
          "description": "SEO Services (Monthly)",
          "quantity": 2,
          "rate": 300,
          "item_total": 600
```


Parameters | Settings — Execute step

Import cURL

Method: POST

URL: https://www.zohoapis.in/books/v3/bills?organization_id={{$json.orgId}}

Authentication: Generic Credential Type

Generic Auth Type: OAuth2 API

OAuth2 API: zoho

Send Query Parameters: off

Send Headers: on

Specify Headers: Using JSON

OUTPUT — Schema | Table | JSON

1 item


```
[
  {
    "code": 0,
    "message": "The bill has been created.",
    "bill": {
      "bill_id": "3781585000000051002",
      "purchaseorder_ids": [
      ],
      "non_catalog_items_count": 2,
      "vendor_id": "3781585000000048001",
      "vendor_name": "Alpha Tech Solutions Pvt. Ltd.",
      "source": "Api",
      "can_amend_transaction": false,
      "contact_category": "",
      "invoice_conversion_type": "invoice",
      "unused_credits_payable_amount": 0,
      "status": "open",
      "color_code": "",
      "current_sub_status_id": "",
      "current_sub_status": "open",
      "sub_statuses": [
      ],
      "bill_number": "INV-2026-001",
      "date": "2026-05-01",
      "is_pre_gst": false,
      "due_date": "2026-05-16",
```

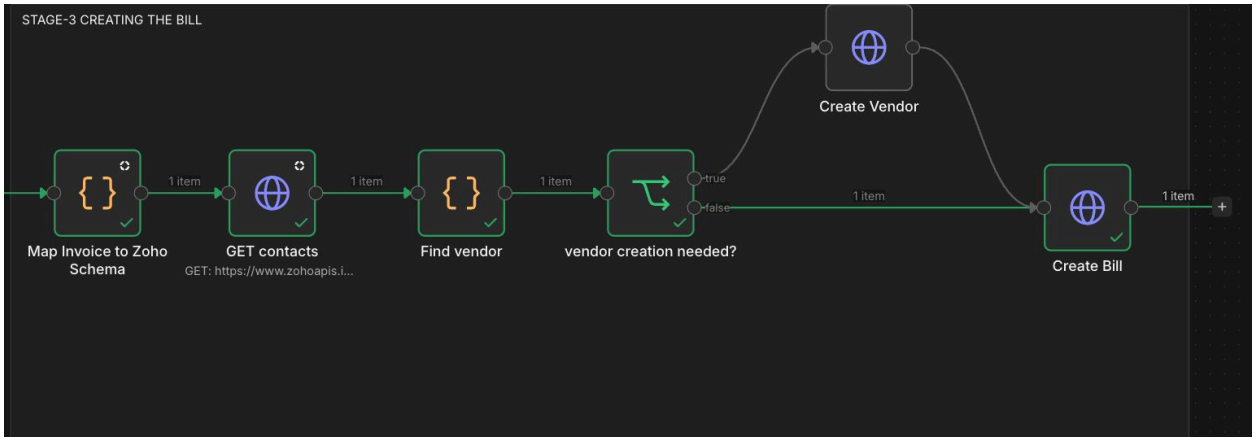

Planned India Data Center Maintenance on 10th May 2026 and 17th May 2026, between 06.30AM to 09.30AM IST. Know more — Don't show again

Home
Items
Sales
Purchases
- Vendors
- Expenses
- Recurring Expenses
- Purchase Orders
- Bills
- Recurring Bills
- Payments Made
- Vendor Credits

Time Tracking
Banking
Accountant
Reports
Documents
APPS

Open Bills — + New

DATE	BILL#	REFERENCE NUMBER	VENDOR NAME	STATUS	DUE DATE
01/05/2026	INV-2026-001		Alpha Tech Solutions Pvt. Ltd.	OPEN	16/05/2026


STAGE-3 CREATING THE BILL
Map Invoice to Zoho Schema
1 item
GET contacts
GET: https://www.zohoapis.i...
1 item
Find vendor
1 item
vendor creation needed?
true
false
Create Vendor
1 item
Create Bill
1 item

4. Stage 4 (Submit and Confirm) - Complete

Send Confirmation Mail

Docs

INPUT

Schema | Table | JSON

bill status

True Branch | False Branch (1 item)


```
[
  {
    "code": 0,
    "message": "The bill has been created.",
    "bill": {
      "bill_id": "3781585000000051002",
      "purchaseorder_ids": [
      ],
      "non_catalog_items_count": 2,
      "vendor_id": "3781585000000048001",
      "vendor_name": "Alpha Tech Solutions Pvt.
                     Ltd.",
      "source": "Api",
      "can_amend_transaction": false,
      "contact_category": "",
      "invoice_conversion_type": "invoice",
      "unused_credits_payable_amount": 0,
      "status": "open",
      "color_code": "",
      "current_sub_status_id": "",
      "current_sub_status": "open",
      "sub_statuses": [
      ],
      "bill_number": "INV-2026-001",
```


Parameters | Settings | Execute step

Credential

Gmail account

Resource

Message

Operation

Send

To

```
{{ $node["Gmail Trigger"].json["From"].split("<")
[1].replace(">", "") }}
```

saloniksawant@gmail.com

Subject

```
Invoice Received & Logged — {{ $('Parse XML to JS
ON').item.json.invoice.invoice_number }}
```

Invoice Received & Logged — INV-2026-001

Email Type

HTML

Message

```
<p>Dear {{ $('Parse XML to JSON').item.json.invoi
ce.vendor_name }},</p>
```

OUTPUT

Schema | Table | JSON

1 item


```
[
  {
    "id": "19de06110ee3806c",
    "threadId": "19de06110ee3806c",
    "labelIds": [
      "SENT"
    ]
  }
]
```


Logs

Clear execution

Invoice Received & Logged — INV-2026-001 Inbox ×

salonisawant04102006@gmail.com 3:22 AM (9 minutes ago)

to me

Dear Alpha Tech Solutions Pvt. Ltd.,

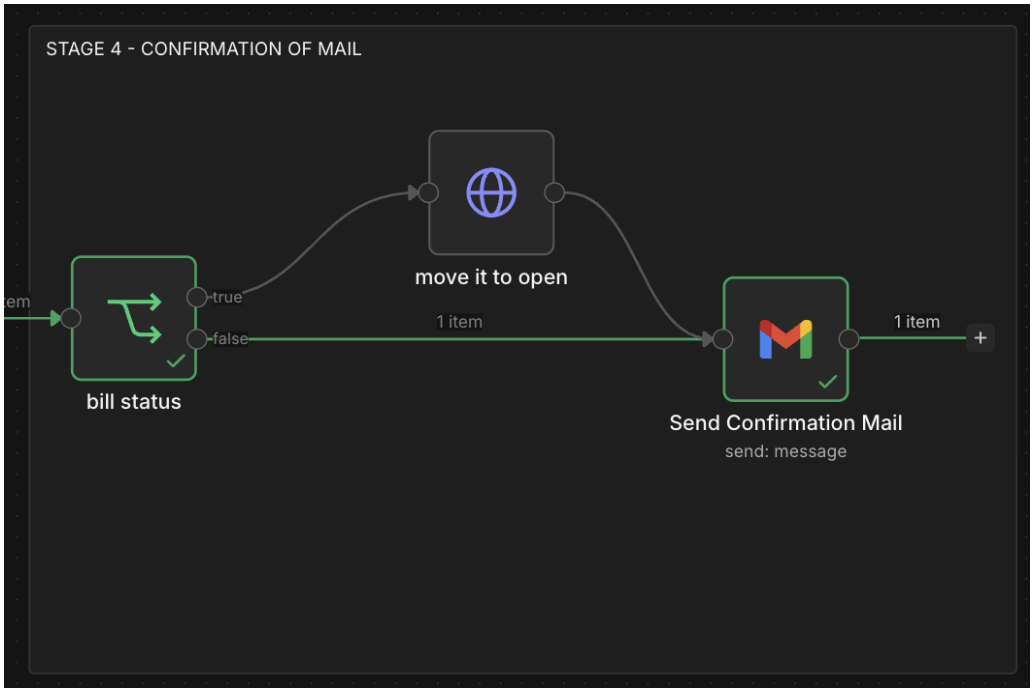
Thank you for sending your invoice. We have successfully received and logged the following in our accounts payable system:

Invoice Number	INV-2026-001
Invoice Date	2026-05-01
Amount Due	USD 980
Due Date	2026-05-16
ERP Reference	3781585000000051002

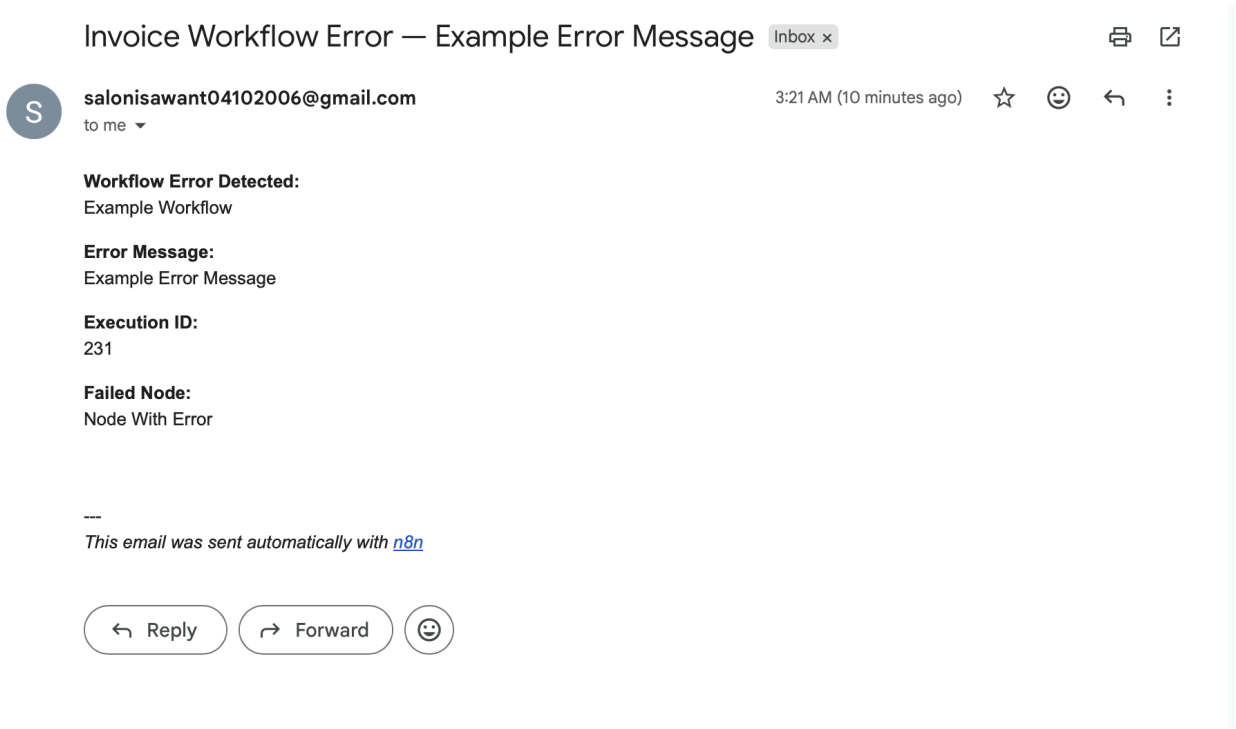
The invoice is now under review. Payment will be processed in accordance with the agreed payment terms.

Best regards,
Accounts Payable Team

This email was sent automatically with n8n


STAGE 4 - CONFIRMATION OF MAIL
move it to open
1 item
true
false
bill status
1 item
Send Confirmation Mail
send: message

TRIGGER MSG -


Invoice Workflow Error — Example Error Message
Inbox ×
S
salonisawant04102006@gmail.com
to me
3:21 AM (10 minutes ago)
Workflow Error Detected:
Example Workflow
Error Message:
Example Error Message
Execution ID:
231
Failed Node:
Node With Error

This email was sent automatically with n8n
Reply
Forward